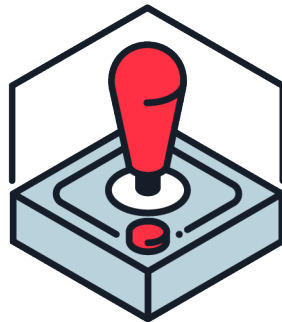




Video Game Metadata Schema: Controlled Vocabulary for TROPES

University of Washington Information School
Game Research (GAMER) Group and
Seattle Interactive Media Museum



GAMER
GAME RESEARCH GROUP

Release 1.1
2024-12-12

Research Team

Main Contributors

Jin Ha Lee, Ph.D. (jinhalee@uw.edu)

Marc Schmalz (mschmalz@uw.edu)

Michele Newman (mmn13@uw.edu)

Lane D. Koughan (kirogata@uw.edu)

Past Editors: Andrew Perti (Seattle Interactive Media Museum); Jill Boyd (University of Washington); Rebecca Fronczak (University of Washington); Katie Wilson (University of Washington)

Suggested Citation

Please cite this document as follows:

Lee, J. H., Schmalz, M., Newman, M., & Koughan, L. D. (2024). *UW/SIMM Video Game Metadata Schema: Controlled Vocabulary for Tropes*. Version 1.1. Retrieved from: <https://github.com/uw-gamergroup/vocabulary-theme>

Version History

1.1: September 2024

1.1: December 2024, Formatting update: Updated reference structure for improved visual clarity and ease of use, with no changes to content. Table formatting was removed, and relationships between terms are now displayed hierarchically through indentation, with narrower terms shown as subsets of broader terms. Included relevant term relationships (SN, USE, USE FOR, RT) as appropriate.

Abbreviation Key

The following abbreviations are used throughout:

SN: Scope note

USE: Preferred term (See)

USE FOR: Equivalent term, lead-in term

RT: Related term (See also)

Controlled Vocabulary for Tropes

Note: Our CV operates with two main buckets. The first bucket is for Character Tropes. These are tropes that appear within the characters of the game and often give the player clues to the personality types or fighting styles of the characters. The second bucket is the Narrative Tropes bucket. These are commonly used tools storytellers employ to convey a message that is understood or recognizable within one or more cultures. These tropes are not mutually exclusive. Oftentimes one trope can become another throughout the story. For example, The Average Individual can become The Chosen One by the end of the game. It is reasonable to use both tropes when describing the character. Additionally, a single game may have many tropes for the characters within the game and the narrative that drives it.

Instructions: Select up to five tropes for each bucket.

Character Tropes – Archetypal Pro/Antagonists

The Strong Female Lead

SN: A strong, independent female character that is central to the story.

RT: **The Affirmative Action Girl, The Femme Fatale**

Example: Lara Croft from *Tomb Raider* and Bayonetta from *Bayonetta*

The Ideal Hero

SN: This male character often appears the same across many different games. For example, in many games there is a white male character with a buzz-cut and a strong jawline.

Example: Master Chief from the *Halo* franchise

The Bold Explorer

SN: This is a character driven by the quest to discover new lands, ideas, people, and experiences. This is different from The Conquer in that they do not need to possess the new item, location, or idea. The experience is often enough.

Example: The protagonists of *Uncharted Waters*, specifically Ernst

The Collector

SN: A character whose motivating factor is to collect all of something.

Example: The main antagonist in *LittleBigPlanet*

The Builder

SN: A character whose motivating factor is to create or construct something, typically physical. This is often an empire or civilization that might also be for their private use.

Example: Some individuals playing *Minecraft* and the Prince from *Katamari Damacy*

The Determinator

SN: A character with relentless persistence and unyielding determination, often pushing through extreme adversity or impossible odds without giving up.

RT: **The Revolutionary(ies)**

Example: Naruto from *Naruto Shippuden: Ultimate Ninja Storm 4* and Phoenix Wright from *Ace Attorney*

The Ranger

SN: A person who spends most of their time in the outdoors and who is proficient at hunting, tracking, and wilderness survival.

Example: Anden Goodmanner from *A Dance with Rogues*

USE FOR: **The Hunter**

The Hunter

USE: **The Ranger**

The Average Individual

SN: This character has no exceptional abilities.

USE FOR: **The Ordinary High School Student**

RT: **The Reluctant Hero**

Example: The protagonist from *Persona 3*

The Ordinary High School Student

USE: **The Average Individual**

The Chosen One

SN: This character has been chosen by their people or divine beings to make a difference in the world.

RT: **The Reluctant Hero, The Sacrificial Lamb, The Vessel/Conduit, The Magic User**

Example: Link from *Zelda*

The Reluctant Hero

SN: A character that does not want to take an active role in the story, but finds they should or must.

RT: **The Chosen One, The Sacrificial Lamb, The Vessel/Conduit, The Magic User, The Average Joe**

Example: Chun Li from the *Street Fighter* franchise

The Secret Police

SN: Police or police-like figures that use questionable or subversive methods to investigate possible crimes against the state or the main authority.

RT: **The Evil Rich Person, The Spy/Spymaster**

Example: Any government operative in *Deus X*

The Spy/Spymaster

SN: An individual whose job it is to coordinate and gather information. Often an indispensable ally.

RT: **The Evil Rich Person, The Secret Police, The Rogue/Stealth**

Example: Hiram Burrows from *Dishonor*

The Evil Rich Person

SN: Money buys power. And power often corrupts.

RT: **The Fat Bastard**

Example: The *Mario* series generally features wealthy, evil royalty

The Big Bad

SN: This character may or may not have powers, but he/she/it is the main antagonist of the story. This is usually the final boss in a game. Defeating The Big Bad will make the hero triumphant.

RT: **The Demonic Foe, The Antichrist, The Eldritch Abomination, The Overlord**

Example: The Lord of Terror from *Diablo*

The Sadistic Instructor

SN: This character takes pleasure in making their pupil suffer. An example could be a particularly mean drill sergeant.

Example: Principal Hanya from *Persona 2*

The Dangerous Relative

SN: This character is someone related to the main character or a trusted family friend or advisor. They represent a threat to the main character.

Example: Balin from *Dragon Age: Origins*

The Reluctant Villain

SN: This character cannot achieve their goals within legal or moral restrictions, so they reluctantly take matters into their own hands. Conversely, they may also be following laws or moral restrictions to the letter, despite reservations.

RT: **The Cursed Beast**

Example: Daisy Fitzroy from *BioShock Infinite*

The Outlaw

SN: A character who operates outside of the law for good or evil.

RT: **The Pirates, The Revolutionary(ies)**

Example: The main character from *Red Dead Redemption*

The Unsettling Child

SN: This character is a young child or adolescent that may or may not actually be creepy, but they project a creepy or unusual demeanor. Unlike the Deadly Child, they may not be violent or skilled.

Example: The Little Sisters from *BioShock*

The Deadly Child

SN: This character is a young child or adolescent that may not seem dangerous at first glance, but they are either formidable fighters or have supernatural powers.

Example: The children who live in Little Lamplight in *Fallout 3* and Annie from *League of Legends*

The Convenient Orphan

SN: This character has no parents or guardians to keep them in place when they are first introduced to the player.

RT: **The Chosen One**

Example: Ellie from *The Last of Us*, Squall from *Final Fantasy 8*

The Amnesiac Hero

SN: This character has no memory of events that took place immediately before the start of the story.

Example: Dust from *Dust: An Elysian Tail*, the main character of *Amnesia: The Dark Descent*

Character Tropes – Exceptional Beings

The Cursed Beast

SN: This character was once a human or human-like life form that was changed into an animal or monster that may be misunderstood by other characters.

RT: **The Reluctant Villain**

Example: Kronos from *Kronos God of War* or any werewolf characters

The Demonic Foe

SN: A character that is from an underworld and represents a greater evil.

RT: **The Big Bad**

Example: Magus of *Chrono Trigger*

The Antichrist

SN: The character that is the highest member of an evil hierarchy, often from the underworld.

RT: **The Big Bad**

Example: Sephiroth from *Final Fantasy VII*

The Eldritch Abomination

SN: This character is a creature that has never been seen before, like Cthulhu.

RT: **The Big Bad**

Example: The Reapers from the *Mass Effect* franchise

The Threshold Guardian

SN: This character possesses knowledge or has access to something that the main characters need to move forward in the story.

USE FOR: **The Librarian**

Example: Faralda from *The Elder Scrolls V: Skyrim*

The Living Statue

SN: This is a character or characters that were once inanimate and then activated by another character.

RT: **Mooks**

Example: The colossi in *Shadow of the Colossus*

The Disembodied Voice

SN: This character may be a voice heard over an intercom or a supernatural being.

RT: **The Threshold Guardian**

Example: Ness' father in *Earthbound*

The Undead

SN: Any undead or otherwise supernaturally animated creature that was once alive.

Example: This can include vampires and zombies

Character Tropes – Leaders

The Runaway Royal

SN: A person with noble lineage who skirts responsibility or wants to be free from their responsibilities.

RT: **The Prince(ss) in Disguise**

Example: Marle from *Chrono Trigger*

The Prince(ss) in Disguise

SN: A character that may or may not be aware of their royal blood, but is hidden for one reason or another.

RT: **The Runaway Royal**

Example: Alistair in *Dragon Age: Origins* and Zelda (as Sheik) from the *Legend of Zelda: Ocarina of Time*

The Overlord

SN: This character may represent some sort of evil and controls a vast army of minions. They may or may not be the main antagonist.

Example: Dr. Robotnik from *Sonic the Hedgehog*

The Conqueror

SN: A character whose primary objective is to possess and control lands, people, and resources in order to increase their power.

RT: **The Overlord**

Example: Walhart from *Fire Emblem Awakening*

The Commander

SN: A person in charge of a combat unit or armed forces.

RT: **The War Veteran**

Example: Commander Shepard from the *Mass Effect* franchise

Character Tropes – Allies

The Animal Sidekick

SN: A creature that accompanies the main character throughout the story.

RT: **The Threshold Guardian, The Sprite**

Example: Cedric the Owl from *King's Quest V*

The Adorable Minion(s)

SN: An individual character or group of small creatures that work for a particular individual and their ultimate goal.

RT: **The Mooks**

Example: The Tonberry and Moogle from the *Final Fantasy* franchise

The War Veteran

SN: A character that has experienced combat and that experience of combat is formative to their personality.

RT: **The Commander**

Example: Cole Phelps from *L.A. Noire*

The Sacrificial Lamb

SN: A character that is due to be sacrificed to a greater cause either by divine prophecy or as collateral damage.

RT: **The Reluctant Hero, The Vessel/Conduit**

Example: Zero from *Mega Man X*

The Mooks

SN: A commonly encountered and dispensable enemy employed by the antagonist character operating individually or in a larger group.

RT: **The Horde, The Adorable Minion(s)**

Example: The Storm Troopers from the *Star Wars* franchise

The Hostages

SN: Characters who are held captive by the antagonist in order to leverage the protagonist into doing the bidding of the antagonist. They generally require rescue.

Example: Promo Girl from the *Resident Evil 3: Nemesis* during *Operation: Mad Jackal*

The Funny Helper

SN: A character that is not immediately perceived as useful and relied on by a storyteller for comic relief. However, their guidance or assistance for a quest makes them indispensable.

RT: **The Animal Sidekick, The Adorable Minion(s)**

Example: Navi from *Legend of Zelda: Ocarina Of Time*

The Vessel/Conduit

SN: An individual chosen by divine intervention for some higher purpose. This purpose may include acting as a "fifth element" (a physical embodiment of a concept) or host.

RT: **The Reluctant Hero, The Sacrificial Lamb, The Magic User**

Example: Dorman in *Shadow of the Colossus*

The Underworld God

SN: A character who rules the underworld.

RT: **The Demon Foe, The Eldritch Abomination**

Example: The Seven Great Evils in the *Diablo* series

The Sprite

SN: A small icon or creature that assists a character throughout their story and may offer special skills to a player such as enhancing an attack.

RT: **The Animal Sidekick**

Example: Navi from *Legend of Zelda: Ocarina Of Time* and Pix from *League of Legends*

The Morality Pet

SN: A character that mediates another character's morality.

RT: **The Badass and Child Duo.**

Example: Raphael's daughter Amy from *Soul Calibur*

The Designated Victim

SN: A character who is perpetually in danger due to their innocence or naiveté and they are usually saved by the protagonist.

Example: Princess Peach from the *Mario* franchise

The Good All Along Character

SN: A character who is believed to be evil at the beginning of the story, though investigation or new information is actually revealed to be an ally or "good guy."

Example: No example provided for this due to possible spoilers. Proceed with caution when assigning this trope.

Character Tropes – Philosophies and Cultures

The Barbarian(s)

SN: A group of people outside of the main society that usually live without technology and operate on a tribal system of governance.

RT: **The Mooks**

Example: Centaurs in *World of Warcraft*

The Assimilator(s)

SN: An individual or group of characters that holds a philosophical belief that everyone must be similar or the same.

RT: **The Fundamentalist(s), The Evil Rich Person, The Secret Police, The Conqueror**

Example: The Geth from *Mass Effect* or The Borg from *Star Trek* franchise

The Fundamentalist(s)

SN: An individual or group of characters driven solely by the strength of their beliefs in politics or religion to the point of which they try to convert anyone to their point of view.

RT: **The Revolutionary(ies)**

Example: The Qunari from *Dragon Age*

The Heretic(s)

SN: An individual or group of characters that go against the ideological flow of a larger group with possible risks to their well being.

Example: Nero from *Devil May Cry 4*

The Isolationist(s)

SN: An individual or small group of characters that believe they must stay separate from a larger population.

RT: **The Evil Rich Person**

Example: The Mages' Collective from *Dragon Age* and the Gerudo tribe from *Legend of Zelda: Ocarina Of Time*

The Revolutionary(ies)

SN: A group or individual whose primary goal is to change the status quo.

RT: **The Outlaw, The Chosen One, The Ideal Hero, The Reluctant Hero**

Example: The Alliance from the *Star Wars* franchise

The Pirate(s)

SN: An individual or group of characters that steal large quantities of goods (government or private property), usually on some sort of large transport vessel.

RT: **The Outlaw**

Example: The pirates from *The Pirates of the Caribbean* franchise

The Otherworldly Visitor(s)

SN: An individual or group of characters that come from a different world or time.

RT: **The Conqueror**

Example: The Four Masks from *Shadow Hearts*

The Horde

SN: Typically an army or gathering that has strength in numbers and are enemy or other to the main protagonists.

USE FOR: **The Swarm**

RT: **The Barbarian(s)**

Example: Orcs from *The Lord of the Rings* franchise

The Swarm

USE: **The Horde**

Character Tropes – Fighting Style

The Brawler

SN: A character that is quick to fight and often has a short temper.

RT: **The Tank**

Example: Liquid Snake from *Metal Gear Solid*

The Magic User

SN: A wizard, witch, or other character that has supernatural powers.

RT: **The Chosen One**

Example: Vivi from *Final Fantasy VII*

The Girly Fighter

SN: A character that uses methods that are based in gendered stereotypes (i.e. fighting with a skillet). This character may also have extreme flexibility or unlikely acrobatics and may have physically revealing fighting styles that male characters would not employ in order for the storyteller or game designer to show off the female body.

RT: **The Strong Female Lead**

Example: Momoko from *The King of Fighters*, commonly seen in arcade style fighting games such as *Soul Calibur*, *Street Fighter*, *Mortal Kombat*, etc.

The Tank

SN: A character that is the target of assault and sustains the most damage during battle. Often they are used strategically to draw attention away from weaker characters so they can pursue their own directives.

USE FOR: **The Burly Bruiser**

RT: **The Badass and Child Duo**

Example: The Heavy from *Team Fortress 2*

The Rogue

SN: A character that employs stealth, dirty fighting, and agile techniques to inflict the most damage on enemies while avoiding taking damage themselves.

USE FOR: **The Assassin**

RT: **The Spy/Spymaster**

Example: The main characters in *Assassin's Creed*

The Assassin

USE: **The Rogue**

Character Tropes – Appearance as Personality

Aloof, Dark Haired Girl

SN: A character distinguished by her dark hair, often depicted as emotionally distant and mysterious.

RT: **The Femme Fatale**

Example: Ada Wong from *Resident Evil*

The Gentle Giant

SN: This character may seem formidable based on its appearance, but it is actually an ally.

Example: Claude from *Shining Force 2*

White Hair, Black Heart

SN: A character with white or silver hair who is ruthless and malevolent, in contrast to their striking appearance.

Example: Sephiroth from *Final Fantasy VII*

Blondes are Dumb/Vain/Villains

SN: A character who is portrayed as stereotypically attractive but lacking in intelligence.

RT: **The Strong Female Lead, The Cute Bruiser**

Example: King Cailan from *Dragon Age: Origins*

Fat Bastard

SN: A character who is overweight and portrayed in a negative light.

RT: **The Evil Rich Person**

Example: Wario from the *Mario* franchise

Character Tropes – Gender

The Patriarch

SN: A male head of a family or tribe.

Example: Sun Jian in the *Dynasty Warriors* series

The Matriarch

SN: A female head of a family or tribe.

Example: Benezia from *Mass Effect*

The Girl in the Boys Club

SN: The female character in the story or game that embodies typically masculine traits.

Example: Seong Mi-na from *Soul Calibur*

The Cute Bruiser

SN: A cute, diminutive character that packs a powerful punch or has a prickly personality.

RT: **The Badass and Child Duo**

Example: Kirby from the *Kirby* franchise and Shantotto from *Final Fantasy XI*

The Burly Bruiser

USE: **The Tank**

The Femme Fatale

SN: A female character that is deadly and often has a tragic backstory.

RT: **The Strong Female Lead, The Femme Fatale**

Example: Maggie Chow in *Deus Ex*

The Affirmative Action Girl

SN: The single female character in the story or game of all male characters.

RT: **The Strong Female Lead**

Example: Of the four playable characters in *Borderlands*, only one is female

The Manic Pixie Dream Girl

SN: A female character whose sole reason of existence is to enliven the life of (a usually male) character.

Example: Catherine from *Catherine*

The Ms. Male Character

SN: A female version of a character that was originally male.

Example: Ms. Pac Man and Toadette from *Mario* franchise

The Woman as Decor

SN: When female characters are depicted in games only as objects to be rescued, sexually pursued, or protected and otherwise serves no function in the narrative.

Example: Any sex worker or groupie in *Saints Row* or women in the *Grand Theft Auto* franchise

Character Tropes – Race

The Token Black Person

SN: When there is one black person in a cast of otherwise white characters.

Example: Nick Meyer from *Snake's Revenge*

The Asian Tech Genius

SN: When the Asian character is really good with STEM subjects to the exclusion of other skills, particularly social skills.

Example: Jung Park from *Rainbow Six*

The Native Shaman

SN: When an indigenous character has a connection or powers relating to the Earth or animals and this is usually an inherited trait from a tribe or their ancestry.

Example: Nightwolf from the *Mortal Kombat* franchise

The Minority Alien Stand-In

SN: When a character is of alien origins is meant to represent an analog to real-world ethnicities or races and these real-world ethnicities or races do not appear in the universe otherwise.

Example: The Syreen from *Star Control 2* and several races from the *Mass Effect* franchise

The Exotic Black Woman

SN: A form of "blacksplotation" that simultaneously sexualizes and defeminizes a black female character.

Example: Vivienne from *Dragon Age*

Character Tropes – Teams

The Badass and Child Duo

SN: Typically a larger individual who is paired with a young child with the “badass” providing protection and support for the child.

RT: **The Tank, The Odd Couple**

Example: Corvo Attano and Emily Kaldwin from *Dishonor*

The Odd Couple

SN: When two characters compliment each other in terms of physical appearance or personalities. Often one is more serious than the other.

RT: **The Bickering Henchmen, The Badass and Child Duo**

Example: Fia and Lian in *Riviera: The Promised Land*

The Bickering Henchmen

SN: Two to three individuals aligned with the antagonists that cannot seem to agree on anything.

Example: The brothers in *Myst*

The Fantastic Four

SN: A team of four individuals who all compliment each other in appearance, skills, and/or fighting styles.

Example: The Black, White, Red, and Yellow birds from *Angry Birds*

The Found Family

SN: A group of characters who, despite not being biologically related, form deep, supportive bonds that provide emotional connection, belonging, and mutual care, often overcoming shared struggles or challenges together.

Example: The Straw Hat crew in *One Piece: World Seeker*, The Shepherds in *Fire Emblem Awakening*

Narrative Tropes – Mortality

Face/Heel Turn

SN: When a character changes their alliance unexpectedly and sticks with their choice.

RT: **Former Friends, Now Foes**

Friends, Not Food

SN: When a character struggles with the desire to connect with others despite them being a food source for them.

RT: **The Morality Pet**

End Justify the Means

SN: When a character takes action that negatively impacts others to achieve a perceived “greater good.”

RT: **The Reluctant Villain, The Determinator**

Too Good for this World

SN: A character so pure and perfect that they cannot live in this world and thus they get killed, often driving the main character to greater feats of heroics on their behalf.

RT: **The Manic Pixie Dream Girl**

Sadistic Choice

SN: When a character or group of characters is presented with a lose-lose choice from their foe (i.e., choose between two loved ones).

RT: **The Big Bad**

Narrative Tropes – Driving Actions

Placate the Thing

SN: When a character needs or soothes a creature that would normally intend harm in order to get past them.

RT: **The Cursed Beast**

Assemble the Thing

SN: When a character or group of characters needs to create something in order to move forward with the story.

RT: **The Builder**

Escape the Labyrinth

SN: When a character or characters must find their way through a maze or maze-like setting.

Slay the Dragon

SN: When a character or group of characters needs to defeat a beast based on a request from the public or an individual or a serendipitous encounter.

Find the Thing

SN: When a character or team needs to locate a particular item, creature, or individual in order to move forward with the story.

RT: **The Ranger, The Brave Explorer**

Perpetually Saving Private Ryan

SN: This trope occurs when a character or a group of characters continually rescues one particular character.

RT: **The Designated Victim**

Narrative Tropes – Call to Adventure

Bad Guy Done Us Wrong

SN: Sometimes unrelated characters band together because they were each wronged in a similar or different way by the same character.

RT: **The Enemy of my Enemy...**

Destiny Reveal

SN: When a character learns something important about their future or receives a calling from a higher power.

RT: **The Chosen One, The Sacrificial Lamb, The Vessel/Conduit, The Reluctant Hero**

Another Dimension

SN: When a character or group of characters is pulled into another dimension and needs to find a way home.

RT: **The Otherworldly Visitor(s), The Reluctant Hero**

Resistance is Futile

SN: A large entity seems like an insurmountable foe, but a small group of resistance fighters come together to attempt to defeat them.

RT: **The Assimilator(s), The Revolutionary(ies), The Determinator**

Narrative Tropes – Team Building

With Our Powers Combined

SN: When two characters enhance their powers by joining their efforts or physical items to create a larger item. Sometimes this can also mean a bond of a spiritual sort.

RT: **The Odd Couple, The Fantastic Four**

The Enemy of my Enemy...

SN: When two characters or teams from opposing sides join forces to defeat a common foe.

RT: **The Odd Couple**

Former Friends, Now Foes

SN: When two or more characters were once allies, but events in the past have pushed them apart to the point at which they are now enemies.

Narrative Tropes – Climax

Darkest Before the Dawn

SN: At the climax of the story, everything seems hopeless.

RT: **The Determinator**

Hail Mary

SN: At the climax of the story, this is the last-ditch effort made by the protagonists or teammates to overcome their trials. It often accompanies a “this is so crazy it just might work” type of plan.

Heroic Sacrifice

SN: At the climax of the story, one of the main characters sacrifices themselves to save others.

RT: **The Sacrificial Lamb, Too Good for this World, The Good All Along Character**

Almost Dead Killshot

SN: At the climax of the story, one of the characters that the players thought was dead (or nearly dead) delivers a mortal wound to their opponent, often saving another individual in the process.

Pointless Revenge

SN: At the climax, once revenge has been achieved for a character for whom it was the driving force, new information comes to light that renders the revenge unethical or unnecessary even though it has already happened.

Narrative Tropes – Endings

I Choose to Stay

SN: At the end of the story, one of the characters chooses to stay in the new setting instead of going home with their teammates (if they have any).

RT: **The Bold Explorer, The Otherworldly Visitor(s)**

But Now I Must Go

SN: At the end of the story, one of the main protagonists leaves the group after their ordeal is over.

RT: **The Isolationist(s), The Reluctant Hero**

Ambiguous

SN: At the end of the game players are unsure of the ending- it could go multiple ways.

Example: *BioShock Infinite*